Funerary beliefs and symbolism in Ancient Egyptian elite tombs

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In this essay I will be addressing the nature of tomb decoration in light of the Old Kingdom. By looking at examples from Old Kingdom elite tombs, I will consider their decoration and how this might be reflective of their funerary beliefs. The scenes of daily life depictions, of painted reliefs and statues demonstrate a care and attention for the tomb where the deceased were to rest for eternity. The depictions and placement of decoration within these tombs can have symbolic and hidden meaning and properties from which the tomb acts as a window into the 'Doubleworld' of the deceased. By exploring the Old Kingdom and elite tomb decoration, it is possible to understand what goods or services were important for the dead and their afterlife. I will be examining in turn the typology of elite burials, their general decorative elements and analysis of these in relation to ancient Egyptian funerary beliefs. With the use of different I examples, I will highlight variations in decoration and interpretive meaning of funerary composition and understood beliefs. I will conclude that there are observable and hidden elements from which meaning cannot be fully obtained. Hinting is a method that alludes to meaning of ancient Egyptian beliefs; however it is a difficult task without social context. Therefore, the understanding of funerary beliefs that can be gained by elite tomb decoration is expansive yet limited by obscurities in what is presented in display and what is absent from tomb decoration.

Typifying Elite Tombs

The Old Kingdom is known as being the '…first classical period of Egyptian culture,' (Grajetzki 2009:16) ushering in architectural and artistic advances and revealing funerary customs and beliefs on a monumental level which has endured for millenniums. Tomb structures associated with the Old Kingdom exist in the form of mastaba mud-brick or stone structures, stepped and peaked pyramids. Though the building of pyramids for royal tombs occurred, mastabas continued to be built during and long after the cessation of the pyramid. Defining these tomb constructions into categories of class or status cannot be differentiated by term alone. Van Walsem (2005) identified 'tomb' as a neutral form of description for tombs from any period of ancient Egyptian burials, he saw it as a necessity to clarify the terms usage in light of his research (2005:18):

> …an elite tomb can be defined as: an architectural complex completely or partially free-standing, respectively cut from the rock, consisting of one or several (substantial) space unities, which is

> inextricably and consciously connected with the mortal remains of the elite, and (was planned to be) provided with decoration, that is iconography and/or texts. (Van Walsem 2005:19)

Van Walsem's definition of 'tomb' in connection to elite burials clearly draws a classification of typology. However, it is the decoration of the tomb that can provide evidence of its elite status and associated depictions connected to funerary beliefs associated with elite burials. Old Kingdom elite tombs stand out from the burial customs of pre-dynastic oval and brick lined pits (Peet 1932:503; Bulshakov 1997:26), mastabas and pyramidal structures marking significantly the burial locations and funerary complexes of this period. The Pyramid Field that extends from the northern area of Gizeh (Giza), to Saqqara, Dahshur and Abusir (Busiri), contains the expansive area of the Old Kingdom pyramids (Peet 1932:508). The primordial mound of which the god brought forth life is also quite representational of these raised mountain-like pyramid monuments of which the Memphite god Ptah is reflected.

Grajetzki (2009) acknowledged that elite burial tombs consisted of a number of major elements which included a closed off underground burial chamber (commonly entered by a shaft); and an accessible aboveground chapel (2009:15). Internal tomb decoration importantly had the feature of the false door where the owner is depicted in front of an offering table with their name and title(s) (2009:15). The false door seems to be bear importance within and outside of the elite being decorated in lower status burials (2009:15). The serdab was also an important feature where the statues of the tomb owner and his family were housed and alternatively act as a 'stand in' in the event that the body was destroyed (2009:16). Though the serdab was not present in elite burials for a short time during the reign of Khufu (Cheops), it had an important significance and returned swiftly in the latter part or at the end of his reign (Grajetzki 2009:18-19).

> As in all periods of Egyptian history, our knowledge of the life of the people of the Old Kingdom, especially the wealthy official class, is derived chiefly from the decoration and contents of their tombs. (Hayes 1946:170)

Bolshakov (2006) places a cautionary note on the exploration of elite tombs and their decoration that are within close proximity to one another. He foreshadows the possibility that tomb decoration could fall into a mimicking form of replication:

> At Saqqara, with tombs scattered over a great territory, the influence of older patterns was not strongly pronounced, while in the compact Giza necropolis where later mastabas used to cluster by the great structures of the ancestry, an artist could much more easily take their decoration as a model for his own work. This engendered not only reproductions of separate scenes, but also the well-known phenomenon of general archaization of murals, epigraphy and of tombs on the whole. (Bolshakov 2006:59)

This is a caution that must be considered, it is unknown to what level of funerary beliefs were practiced as a copied tradition and what was were thriving practice of burial customs that have endured and developed.

Elite Tomb Decoration: Funerary beliefs under question

> …for the best products of art, in sculpture, mural paintings, and in architecture, were devoted originally to the decoration and furnishing of their tombs. …the care of the Egyptians for their dead remained the striking and constant feature of their religion. (Garstang 1907:1)

The classical essence of the Old Kingdom is marked by its iconic associations with ancient Egypt, pyramids and mummification. The development of the pyramids started by Djoser's step pyramid in the Third Dynasty at Saqqara acted as an architectural precedent of which future elite aspired to achieve if not better. The Fourth Dynasty saw the introduction of elite burials undergoing the process of mummification with canopic jars storing the bodily entrails (Grajetzki 2009:15). There appeared to be some form of consistency with the funerary and burial practices of the elite through the Fourth and Fifth Dynasties, however customs changed by the late Old Kingdom during the Sixth Dynasty (Grajetzki 2009:16). Hayes' (1946) study of the Old Kingdom chapel decoration of Kay-em-snewy and reliefs of Ny-kau-Hor's tomb

led to his conclusion that '…many of the monuments of the kings and great nobles of the Sixth Dynasty were conceived with imagination and executed with surpassing skill,' (Hayes 1946:178).

The Old Kingdom was a definite period of decorative and innovative development. Though Egypt's past was marked somewhat iconically by pyramids and mummification as modern signifiers, the social life and funerary beliefs in ancient Egypt were greatly focused around agricultural labour (Peet 1932:484). Their attention to the yielding of crops and the fertile nature of the Nile valley inundation was important for ancient Egyptians in life and in death. Daily scenes connected to marsh and agricultural pursuits were depicted on the tomb walls of the elite and are some of the best preserved from the Old Kingdom (Harpur 1987:175). The purpose of these paintings in conjunction with funerary beliefs of the Old Kingdom can be understood based on the hints and clues that have been left by the tomb decoration and practices learned through the funerary literature of the Pyramid Texts.

Quirke (1992) discussed ancient Egyptian religion in regards to their burial customs and funerary beliefs as something mirrored to our own physical existence. In both life and death we need a source of nourishment. He stated that 'Death was not an enemy nor an obstacle but a doorway to another existence,' (Quirke 1992:141). The question that this brings is how does the deceased get there, what form do they take and what did the ancient Egyptians believed would happen? The first funerary texts that posed answers to such questions were the Pyramid Texts. The texts acknowledge a release, a performance or recitation of utterances to permit this movement. The earliest Old Kingdom example of these funerary texts were inscribed on the walls of Unas' pyramid which filled the available space on the walls in a logical sequence meant to ensure the eternal life of the king (1992:152-153).

Bolshakov (1997) identifies the Pyramid Texts as '…the oldest great written monument of ideological nature in history,' (Bolshakov 1997:19). The funerary beliefs of the ancient Egyptians are vocalised through this mixed corpus of texts fitted and arranged for funerary purposes; these included incantations against snakes and utterances to be repeated in ceremonial performance (Quirke 1992:153). The use of Pyramid Texts was the primary privilege of the King during the Old Kingdom, its later democratisation occurred over the next century appearing on non-royal coffins (Quirke 1992:155). Pyramid Texts fill the wall

space in King Unas' pyramid. This funerary tomb decoration provides us with insight into the written aspects of the funerary beliefs of the ancient Egyptians.

Utterance 224 appears on the Eastern wall of Unas' Sarcophagus Chamber (in line with Faulkner's (1998) translation):

> *Epilogue to Utterance 224*
> How happy is your condition! Your spirit, O King, is among your brothers the gods. How changed it is, how changed it is! Protect your children and beware of this boundary of yours which is on earth. Recite four times: Clothe your body, that you may come to them. (Faulkner 1998:53)

This utterance reflects on the king's transfigured state, a happy condition, a state of being connected to an attainable proximity with the gods.

On the north wall of the antechamber of Unas' pyramid Utterance 302:463 is inscribed. Faulkner's (1998) translation of the Pyramid Text 302:463 exemplify the funerary belief of the king's afterlife:

> Wepwawet has caused me to fly up to the sky among my brethren the gods. I use my arms as a goose, I flap my wings as a kite; the flier flies, O me, I fly away from you. (Faulkner 1998:92)

As you continue to read the Pyramid Texts from the Old Kingdom, there are many references to receiving meals which can be identified with the hopeful continued nourishment of the deceased in the afterlife. The king receiving this nourishment would most certainly be beneficial to the funerary beliefs of ancient Egyptians whose presence was permitted before the gods and could be an intermediary for them. The decoration of later Old Kingdom tombs draw on this theme more by the artistic representation of painted offering scenes bringing realism to the meaning and hope for this nourishment more than by textual offerings. The visual manifestation or iconographic displays would be combined with tangible offerings at

the burial site which would act almost as an assurance that this nourishment was efficiently met for the deceased.

Tomb Decoration: Food for the Soul

Harpur's (1987) examination of the decoration of Old Kingdom tombs saw that the content of scenes in private tombs had a slow development between the Third and Eighth Dynasties (1987:33). There was a span of chronology where lengthy periods did not incur any significant change, and if so, very little (1987:43). Harpur identified that the progression of decoration over the available wall space grew as the repertory of compositions became more elaborate by the Fifth Dynasty, peaking in the Sixth (1987:175).

> Nearly all of the scenes in the Old Kingdom repertory can be assigned to one of eight basic themes: marsh pursuits, agriculture, pastoral activities, horticulture, workshop pursuits, banqueting, the funerary meal, and the funeral ceremonies of the deceased, including his 'journey to the West'. (Harpur 1987:175)

The decorations of elite tombs are embroiled in variations over different periods in Egyptian history. However, it is the food offering scenes and lists that seem to endure consistently in tombs during the Old Kingdom. Quirke (1992) acknowledged that there were two forms of surviving death, spirit of sustenance and spirit of mobility (1992:143). If the Pyramid Texts encouraged the movement of the tomb owner (though not always present in elite burials of the Old Kingdom) there is a symbolism of movement through the activity in painted reliefs either by the presence of food (real or symbolic) encouraging movement to eat, or by reminders of modelled daily activity (in miniature models or painted relief depictions).

> The presence of food offerings in particular implies a continued material use of human faculties after death for offerings require of the deceased both an ability to eat and drink, that is to absorb, as in life, and to move to the place with the offerings, even if this were only a few metres away. (Quirke 1992:143)

The foods visually represented for offering can fall into the categories of overt and covert (shown or alluded to by absence possibly due to an understood commonality), or relating to real and symbolically hidden meanings. The agricultural and animal stocking or trapping scenes in tombs such as Ptahhotep, Nefer (Head of Royal Singers), Neferherenptah (Head of the Hairdressers) and Kagemni (Sixth Dynasty Vizier) demonstrate the association of daily life being important if not common to display in tombs of the elite (Peet 1932; Darby 1977:273; Grajetzki 2009:17). The example from the Sixth Dynasty tomb of Vizier Mereruka, one of the largest non-royal elite tombs at Saqqara, shows hunting in the marshes to humble scenes of poultry given pellet feed, but also unique scenes of animals being force-fed (Darby et al. 1977:287; Oaks & Gahlin 2002:98-99). One of the most common depictions on tomb walls of the elite were servants carrying food including domestic animals and birds which were to be offered to the deceased (1977:273).

The Fourth Dynasty under king Snefru saw interesting tomb decoration in his sons' tombs of Nefermaat and Rahotep. The earlier had chapel reliefs that depicted various scenes of carpenters, farmers ploughing and servants bringing food, everything important for survival in the afterlife (Grajetzki 2009:18). The latter son, Rahotep's tomb was known for its statues of the tomb owner and his wife Nofret, the seated figures exemplified Old Kingdom craftsmanship. In some elite tombs Grajetzki (2009) has noted that even though the chapels were small and burial goods were few, the amount of decoration stood in to represent what was not physically abundant showing scenes of '…the production of food and objects which are thus secured for eternity,' (Grajetzki 2009:18). He continued to state, 'The naming of the most important things in the offering list had the same function: securing the supply of significant items for the afterlife,' (Grajetzki 2009:18).

Darby et al. (1977) makes it clear that the concentration of analysing and examining the tomb decoration of the elite permits the chance to learn about so many aspects, including funerary religious beliefs, by understanding the prominence of agriculture and food production and consumption of ancient Egyptians.

> To know man's food, whether in the twentieth century or in antiquity,
> is to know and understand a host of interrelated knowledge derived

> from archaeology, art, climatology, geography, history, medicine, mythology and religion. (Darby et al. 1977:1)

Darby et al. examined the food and nutritional evidence of ancient Egyptians and in their study revealed that the fertile black land of the Nile valley and its agricultural yielding had religious connotations with creation and life (1977:11). Offering shrines and tables were central for the deceased and their continuation into the afterlife. Food and the yielding of crops through agricultural means from the fertile land of the earth represent religious creationist interplay and hinting that food is divine nourishment. Funerary beliefs can be established in connection with the myth surrounding Geb and Nut's union of the earth and sky (1977:14). The birth of life by the union of earth and sky unites the body with a cosmological entity (or entities if discussing the multiple facets of the soul-like divisions of the ancient Egyptian spirit) representative of the sky (all around you and an essence) with the earth (physical body limited to a tangible nature, being grounded). In death, the k*3* acts as a released element of this union and permits the movement of the deceased in another form. This form of the k*3* is not fully revealed during our life, but is with us at the time of birth and separates or continues to live in the afterlife after death (Bolshakov 1997:209-212). The mastaba or pyramid stands in for the raised fertile primordial mound that the sky meets. The death and burial of the deceased indicates the boundaries of the physical existence and is released to enable a movement between both worlds of the earth and sky (cosmos).

Funerary beliefs extracted through the hidden, absent and Doubleworld

Van Walsem acknowledges that the interpretation of the iconography in tombs has 'intrinsic meaning' and 'symbolical values' where human psychology uses interpretation through the use of symbols to represent themes and concepts (Van Walsem 2005:21). Just as the era of trademarks and corporate logos may infuse ideas of belonging and hold connotations of different services provided, the iconographical displays in elite tomb decoration similarly contain these hints and clues.

Bolshakov (1994) described the art of hinting as a necessary method in the understanding and interpretation of the funerary beliefs through the decoration of elite tombs. He states that there is an ancient system of values that are reflected in tomb decoration and by examining the decoration it is possible to get closer to the values and belief system that existed in

ancient Egypt (1994:9). There is encoded information, as also prescribed by Van Walsem, in the funerary décor that hints at subjects that may not be able to be represented or explained without the use of symbolic or connotative iconography (1994:9). Bolshakov states that hinting was especially done in Old Kingdom tombs, however was '…unnoticed by modern scholars who usually do not conceptualize the tomb as a whole and who cannot sense its organic functioning,' (Bolshakov 1994:9-10).

The Old Kingdom used murals and statues in relation to food offerings. This applied to the tomb of Seneb (Snb) in Gizeh which housed a family statue of Seneb, his wife and his two children (Bolshakov 1994:17; Oakes & Gahlin 2002:83). His tomb is attributed to the latter Fourth Dynasty/early Fifth Dynasty (1994:25). Though Seneb, visually portrayed with dwarfism, may not have been part of the royal elite, his character was recognised and had some form of elite connections during the Old Kingdom. He is represented in a seated pose cross legged with his wife beside him. The funerary beliefs of the ancient Egyptians were concerned with showing the deceased in the best light; negative portrayals of the deceased were not represented in tombs for such a likely reason.

Bolshakov (1994) discussed the significance of the false door in relation to Seneb's tomb. In funerary beliefs, this provided the entry and exit from the tomb of the soul-like entity of the k*3*, and the offering table for the continued nourishment of the deceased for eternity. The false door was a prominent feature in Old Kingdom elite burials, the doorway in which movement can lead the transfigured or other states of the deceased into their Doubleworld.

> Distortions of reality in tomb decorations can be rather conventionally subdivided into two types. Distortions of the first kind leave unpictured all harmful, evil or dangerous aspects of reality and, thus, exclude them from the Doubleworld. By contrast, distortions of the second kind represent something absent in reality, which improves the Doubleworld and transforms into its integral part. The combination of these two groups of distortions essentially allowed Egyptians to alter some features of the Doubleworld as compared with those of the real life. (Bolshakov 1994:26)

The Doubleworld of the k*3* is a better form, albeit distorted from reality, and is meant to mirror our existence of life into death. Observations in tomb decoration show the human form when represented with an ideal physique and appearance. In the case of Seneb, it is perhaps one of the only exceptions of this ideal representation, where dwarfism is permitted (although unknown as to why); there are almost no other exceptions from this ideal aside from foreign representations (Bolshakov 1994:26-27).

According to Bolshakov, if negative distortions or harmful components were left out of Old Kingdom tomb decoration, the depiction of Seneb must not be viewed as harmful to his state. Furthermore, there are a number of other ailments that can be caused from dwarfism affecting the spine and ability to walk, and it could be possible that his height was not a negative expression, but he was portrayed in a healthy and physically able manner that might depict him as mobile, which other ailments suffered might be absent.

Tomb decoration and funerary beliefs alongside the example of Seneb addresses distortion in representation. Bolshakov addressed tomb decoration and its obscurities in that, '…it distorts reality in some respects in order to render the future life better in comparison with the earthly one,' (Bolshakov 1994:25).

In the example of Seneb's tomb, this is one of those unique examples where the physical traits and characteristics of the tomb owner confuses the understanding of the full benefits he obtained by an improvement to his character in the Doubleworld. It is possible that funerary beliefs were impacted by the level of distorted reality that occurred in tomb decoration. In the above quote Bolshakov (1994) discussed two experiences of the 'distortions of reality'. These distortions take into consideration what is not pictured, that which is harmful or evil aspects of reality which is excluded from the Doubleworld of the k*3*; the second is the improvement of the Doubleworld by the addition of something that is otherwise absent from reality (Bolshakov 1994:26; 1997). When assessing funerary beliefs as understood by the examination of elite tomb decoration from any period, we need to be mindful of not only what is represented but what might be absent from the décor. This in itself acts as a hint at other beliefs and meanings that will not be immediately recognisable or understood because of its absence or hidden form of representation.

Conclusion

In this essay I have addressed the nature of tomb decoration during the Old Kingdom looking at examples from elite tombs. Agricultural depictions and servants bringing food are enduring displays. The decorations of elite tombs have symbolic and hidden meanings. Funerary beliefs can be understood by the examination of the depicted scenes and texts that appear in elite tombs demonstrating that there was care in the form of symbolic nourishment and provisions for the deceased in their afterlife. Two of the prominent and enduring features of the funerary beliefs of the ancient Egyptians during the Old Kingdom relate to their attentiveness of decorating the false door for the Doubleworld existence of entering and leaving the tomb (the earthly world) with the ability to move with a cosmological connection to the sky (k*3*); and secondly the continual nourishment by real or represented symbolism of divine food offerings inside the tomb to ensure that the sustenance needed in physical life was provided for in death in their transfigured form.

There are observable and hidden elements from which meaning can only be understood in the context of the lived beliefs of the Old Kingdom period that cannot fully be attained in modern investigations. Hinting as a method merely alludes to meaning and it is a difficult task without social context to understand what may be absent or altered in tomb decoration as a form of overt or covert representation (as exemplified by the ideal form in Seneb's tomb). Therefore, the understanding of funerary beliefs that can be gained by elite tomb decoration is expansive yet limited by obscurities in what is depicted and what is absent from tomb decoration. What can be understood is not a practical interpretation of funerary beliefs, but one that is suggestive and complex.

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